

Macbeth Lit-Anchor Reading

Prophecy Is Not Proof

Lesson 1: Testing Macbeth's Reasoning with Whately's Four Questions

Purpose

A lit-anchor connects the week's logic lesson to a recurring literary text. In Lesson 1, Whately teaches that logic is powerful but limited: it can test whether a conclusion follows from reasons, but it cannot supply wisdom, virtue, or all the facts. *Macbeth* gives us a tragic case. Macbeth hears a prophecy, but the prophecy itself does not tell him what to do. The logical question is not merely, "What did the witches say?" It is: *What does Macbeth conclude from what they say, and has that conclusion been earned?*

Whately's four questions: (1) What is the conclusion? (2) What reason is actually given? (3) What hidden assumption must be true? (4) Does the conclusion really follow?

Central Question

When Macbeth hears a prophecy, what does he conclude—and does that conclusion actually follow?

Reading Focus

As you read, mark the places where Macbeth moves from what he has been told to what he imagines, assumes, fears, or wants.

Reading I: Act 1, Scene 3

The witches greet Macbeth with three titles. One is already true, one is about to be confirmed, and one points to a possible future. Watch how Macbeth and Banquo respond differently once part of the prophecy seems true.

The Witches

All hail, Macbeth! hail to thee, thane of Glamis!
All hail, Macbeth, hail to thee, thane of Cawdor!
All hail, Macbeth, thou shalt be king hereafter!

Macbeth

The witches give Macbeth three titles: one present, one unknown to him but already granted, and one future.

Stay, you imperfect speakers, tell me more:
By Sinel's death I know I am thane of Glamis;
But how of Cawdor? the thane of Cawdor lives,
A prosperous gentleman; and to be king
Stands not within the prospect of belief,
No more than to be Cawdor. Say from whence
You owe this strange intelligence? or why
Upon this blasted heath you stop our way
With such prophetic greeting? Speak, I charge you.

Ross

And, for an earnest of a greater honour,
He bade me, from him, call thee thane of Cawdor:
In which addition, hail, most worthy thane!
For it is thine.

Banquo

What, can the devil speak true?

Macbeth, aside

Glamis, and thane of Cawdor!
The greatest is behind.

Banquo

That trusted home
Might yet enkindle you unto the crown,
Besides the thane of Cawdor. But 'tis strange:
And oftentimes, to win us to our harm,
The instruments of darkness tell us truths,
Win us with honest trifles, to betray's
In deepest consequence.

Macbeth, aside

Two truths are told,
As happy prologues to the swelling act
Of the imperial theme.
Cannot be ill, cannot be good: if ill,
Why hath it given me earnest of success,
Commencing in a truth? I am thane of Cawdor:
If good, why do I yield to that suggestion
Whose horrid image doth unfix my hair

Macbeth asks for evidence. At this moment, he does not simply accept the prophecy.

The second title is confirmed. Macbeth now has a reason to take the rest of the prophecy seriously.

Banquo asks the source-credibility question that Macbeth needs. Truth in one point does not prove trustworthiness in all points.

Macbeth begins moving from one confirmed prediction toward the larger promised future.

Banquo offers a rival interpretation: a true prediction may be bait rather than trustworthy guidance.

Macbeth treats the two truths as prologues to kingship. That is an inference, not merely an observation.

And make my seated heart knock at my ribs,
 Against the use of nature? Present fears
 Are less than horrible imaginings:
 My thought, whose murder yet is but fantastical,
 Shakes so my single state of man that function
 Is smother'd in surmise, and nothing is
 But what is not.

Macbeth, aside

If chance will have me king, why, chance may crown me,
 Without my stir.

Murder enters
 Macbeth's
 imagination before any
 command has been
 given. The prophecy
 does not explicitly tell
 him to murder.

Macbeth briefly sees
 the logical gap: if
 chance will crown him,
 action may not be
 required.

Reasoning Bridge

The witches give Macbeth a prediction. They do not give him a command. They do not say that murder is necessary. They do not say that kingship would be good for Macbeth or Scotland. They do not say that Macbeth may do evil in order to make the prediction come true.

A careful reader can separate at least three claims:

1. **Possible claim:** Macbeth may become king.
2. **Dangerous claim:** Macbeth should act to become king.
3. **Moral claim Macbeth has not proved:** Murder may be a legitimate path to the promised future.

The paired worksheet asks you to test these movements with Whately's four questions.

Reading II: Act 1, Scene 7

Now read Macbeth's soliloquy before Duncan's murder. Macbeth is no longer merely reacting to prophecy. He is weighing reasons.

Macbeth

If it were done when 'tis done, then 'twere well
 It were done quickly: if the assassination
 Could trammel up the consequence, and catch
 With his surcease success; that but this blow
 Might be the be-all and the end-all here,
 But here, upon this bank and shoal of time,
 We'd jump the life to come. But in these cases
 We still have judgment here; that we but teach
 Bloody instructions, which, being taught, return

To plague the inventor: this even-handed justice
 Commends the ingredients of our poison'd chalice
 To our own lips.
 He's here in double trust;
 First, as I am his kinsman and his subject,
 Strong both against the deed; then, as his host,
 Who should against his murderer shut the door,
 Not bear the knife myself. Besides, this Duncan
 Hath borne his faculties so meek, hath been
 So clear in his great office, that his virtues
 Will plead like angels, trumpet-tongued, against
 The deep damnation of his taking-off;
 And pity, like a naked new-born babe,
 Striding the blast, or heaven's cherubim, horsed
 Upon the sightless couriers of the air,
 Shall blow the horrid deed in every eye,
 That tears shall drown the wind. I have no spur
 To prick the sides of my intent, but only
 Vaulting ambition, which o'erleaps itself
 And falls on the other.

Macbeth begins with consequences: if the murder could end the matter, speed might seem attractive; but consequences return.

Macbeth lists duties: kinship, subjecthood, hospitality, and Duncan's virtue.

Macbeth names his only positive motive: ambition. This is not a proof; it is an exposure of desire.

Closing Synthesis

Whately says logic is modest: it cannot supply facts, virtue, or wisdom. Macbeth proves the point. Logic can show that prophecy does not equal permission, that possibility is not command, and that ambition is not proof. Yet Macbeth still needs moral judgment. The tragedy begins not because Macbeth cannot reason, but because he can see reasons clearly and still allows ambition to overrule judgment.